IN PURSUIT OF A DEADLY GOAL

The potential rewards such as better pay and improved living conditions in the US outweigh life-threatening risks of illegal immigration



WHY DO THEY GO?

Based on the interrogation of around 70 individuals who returned from Vatry, Sanjay Kharat, SP, CID, says:

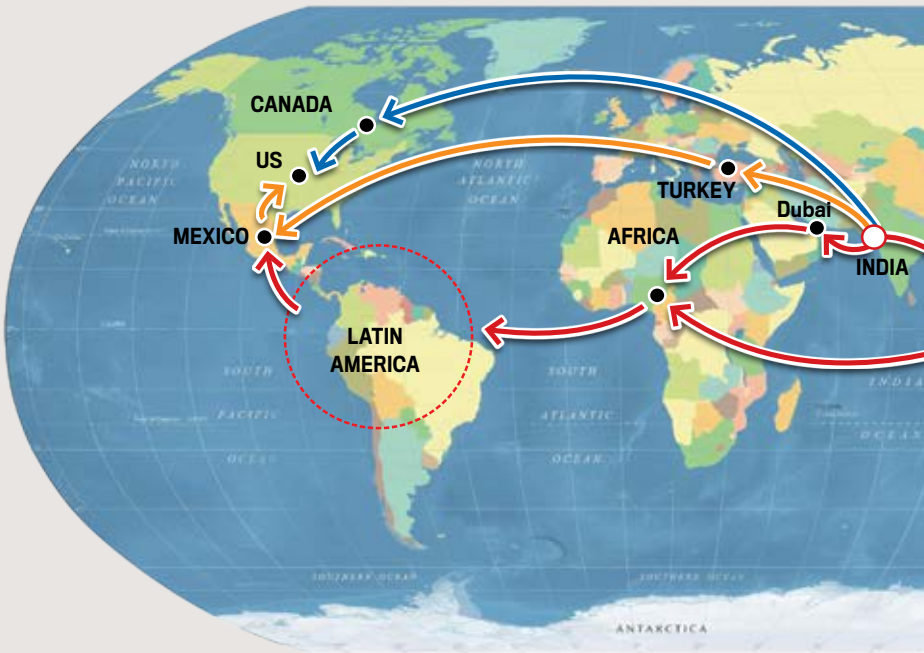
- As families expand, farm land gets split into smaller parcels, making livelihoods unsustainable
- Families can't afford to employ farm labourers, so they have to do the laborious work themselves
- Depending on education and skills, they get jobs here, but a job in the US is more remunerative
- In 200-300 villages/towns in north and central Gujarat, almost every house has at least one member settled there. It keeps the door always half open
- Patel girls prefer boys settled in the US for a comfortable life, also independent of in-laws



WHO FUNDS IT?

- Aspirants—mostly from middle class or lower middle class backgrounds—do not bear the cost of travel at all
- Expenses are borne by US-based potential high-net worth employers from the community who promise to pay the agent only after the aspirant reaches
- The lenders start getting a reasonable return on their 'investment' within three years
- These well-oiled syndicates work on trust within the Gujarati communities, dominated by Patidars but not limited to them
- The homes and farmlands of the aspirants are treated as collateral
- Agents are paid through an opaque Hawala system

FAVOURED 'DUNKI' ROUTES



VIA LATIN AMERICAN AND AFRICAN COUNTRIES

- Agents fly the immigrant to Dubai, Indonesia or Malaysia as a springboard on a valid tourist visa
- Some even fly them to African countries where they cool off for a few months. From there, they charter flights to Latin American countries such as Bolivia, Guyana, Ecuador, Nicaragua. These countries allow on-arrival visas
- The person traverses harsh terrains to reach Mexico on foot through forests or water routes

Duration: Average six months before they reach the US

Cost: ₹70-75 lakh

THE PLAN



MARRIAGE

- The agents facilitate a marriage with an individual in India who is a US citizen
- It's done with an understanding that both the parties will be on their own after reaching the US

Cost
₹1.5 cr.-1.9 cr.

EDUCATIONAL

- Visa agents connive with foreign educational institutions for fake admission offers
- In India, they fake marksheets, financial status, work experience documents etc. to get a genuine visa to send the aspirants off to the intended destination





Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY